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Durkheim and pacifism: contemporary political issues 1900-1914

*W. D. Halls*¹

From 1902, after taking up a lectureship in Paris, until 1914, Durkheim came under attack from right-wing intellectuals. They resented his academic influence; by the end of the first decade they were reproaching him with being 'the master of the Sorbonne', where his sociology, they said, 'Germanized' scholarship. They also sought to probe and, if possible, discredit his political views. In particular, four themes that were the subject of much political discussion in the pre-War Third Republic gave rise to vague accusations against him by his enemies. His patriotism and that of his like-minded colleagues was considered suspect - did he not come from Epinal in Lorraine? Moreover, he was a Jew, excluded *per se* from the French community along with Protestants, foreigners and Freemasons. He allegedly had 'pacifist' leanings, was inclined to 'internationalism', propagated anti-militarism, and demeaned the army. The two hostile articles by Henri Massis that appear in translation below obliquely question in mocking, sarcastic tones his stance on these contemporary issues.

As is well known, Durkheim never concealed his socialist sympathies, but his was a socialism of a moderate kind. He favoured the 'reformist' 'tendency' of Jaurès rather than that of the 'revolutionary' socialists. He approved of a policy of gradualism rather than the violent overthrow of the existing capitalist order. But, unlike many of his associates of the *Année sociologique*, he never formally joined the Section Française de l'Internationale Ouvrière; instead, he strove to keep his distance from the political scene. He may have embraced socialist principles but refused to be involved in practical politics. Nevertheless, one who was above all a moralist could not fail to engage, at least theoretically, with underlying political issues of the day. Massis in his articles questions Durkheim's stance on the contemporary themes of patriotism and pacifism, as well as internationalism and anti-militarism, and the role of the army in national life. Signed 'Agathon', the articles were first published in *Paris Journal* in 1913.

The publication of previous articles attacking the Sorbonne establishment had caused a sensation.² At first those professors targeted surmised that right-wing colleagues were the authors. They were angry when it transpired that the

pseudonym covered the identity of two young men, Henri Massis (1886-1970), their principal author, and Alfred de Tarde.

The same anonymous writers also reported the results of an enquiry into the political and social attitudes of a sample of students and attacked the prevailing ethos of the 'new' Sorbonne.³ The survey, undertaken from May to June 1912, concluded, on the flimsy evidence of an unrepresentative sample drawn mainly from the Catholic 'haute bourgeoisie' and belonging to the *Ligue pour la Culture Française*, that the rising generation, unlike that of 1870, 'the generation of defeat', was non-intellectual. Young men preferred action to introspection and were aggressively patriotic and nationalist. They were not fearful of fighting a war and sought 'la revanche' for the loss of Alsace-Lorraine. They liked sport. They abhorred the secularism and positivism of their mentors. Again, the 'German' Sorbonne came under fire. This new generation could be described as Bergsonian 'vitalists', holding that life originates from a vital principle and not from any physical or mechanistic forces. From the survey, Massis concluded that in the 'grandes écoles' and the 'university proper' there were no anti-patriotic students. For him, 'un esprit de race s'affirme'.⁴ In the first article, 'The miracle-workers of pacifism', Massis purports to give an account of the meeting of the French Philosophical Society held on 30 December 1907 at the Sorbonne. A score of members, including some notable professors, were present.⁵

The meeting was held a year after one bone of contention, the recurring dispute between Germany and France over Morocco, was temporarily resolved. However, in 1911 Germany once more accused France of meddling in Morocco's internal affairs. The Kaiser despatched a gunboat to Agadir. Again a settlement was reached. The flare-up allowed the nationalists to whip up anti-German sentiment, and the cry for the return of Alsace-Lorraine to France was revived. It marked the beginnings of a new wave of militarism that took over in France and Germany and reached its peak in 1914, despite the efforts of 'pacifists' on both sides to stem the tide.

The articles were published at another critical juncture, on the eve of the passing of the 'Three-year law' in August 1913. This measure extended the period of conscription from two to three years. It was a reaction to German moves to build up their war machine - by then many on both sides regarded war as inevitable. The French forces suffered greatly from inferior numbers: hence the extension of military service. Right-wingers favoured the law, whereas socialists and trade unionists opposed it, as did a number of Radicals and pacifists.

Massis had positioned himself on the Right, in effect allying himself with the stance taken by Barrès, Maurras and other nationalists. For Barrès, since the turn of the century a convinced nationalist, patriotism was a matter of sentiment rather than reason. It was based on the cult of 'la terre et les morts' - was not 'patrie' derived from 'patres', 'pères'? To be born on French soil, of pure French race, was to inherit the traditions of one's ancestors. Those 'without the Law' could not share in this heritage, which had to be defended at all costs. Intransigent nationalism, 'my *patrie* right or wrong', also characterised his contemporary, Charles Maurras and Action Française - its slogan was 'La France d'abord' - the burgeoning royalist movement of which he had quickly become the leader. All three 'intellectuals' - though they despised the word - would have no truck with pacifism. Their absolute devotion to France ruled it out.

Anti-patriotism and pacifism - the two were closely linked - had undergone different interpretations, particularly on the Left. In 1864 the founders of the First International had declared that the proletariat had no *patrie*. But in 1906 at their party congress the socialists had formally repudiated by a large majority a resolution proposed by the firebrand Gustave Hervé that the workers should reject 'bourgeois, governmental patriotism' and not fulfil any of their obligations as citizens, including military service in time of war⁶. Durkheim, on the other hand, shared with Jaurès, the socialist party leader, the view that socialism and patriotism were not incompatible. Both disagreed with the trade unionists of the Confédération Générale du Travail, in which by 1900 the anarchist influence had come to dominate, and who were more intransigent. They rejected the very idea of the State, for which they saw no necessity. Hence the concept of patriotism, which they identified with the nation-state, was meaningless. The class struggle was everything. They held that they had more in common with workers everywhere, who like them sought the overthrow of capitalism. This, they believed, could only be accomplished by revolution and was the proper interpretation of internationalism. For Massis this was a justification for alleging that lack of patriotism was linked to pacifist convictions.

Those present at the meeting of the Société Française de Philosophie were not extremists. If they were socialists they were more akin to the German 'socialists of the chair'. Some were inclined to Radicalism; others had no known political views. All were patriotic, although, as will be seen, a few envisaged a broad conception of patriotism that eventually might embrace Europe or even the whole world. Massis did not accept their good faith. For

him there was a coterie of anti-patriots in the Sorbonne that sought to increase its power and support.⁷

Before 1901 the term 'pacifist' did not exist in French. It had in fact been coined on the upper deck of a Glasgow tram on 12 September 1901 by Emile Arnaud, Gaston Moch and others participating in the (non-official) Tenth Universal Peace Congress held in Scotland in 1901.⁸ The word first appeared in print in the *Indépendance belge* when Arnaud wrote:

Our great party [sic] needs a name. We are not passive types; we are something more...we are pacifists and our ideology is pacifism.⁹

What precisely they meant by pacifism was open to many interpretations. The English word has overtones of conscientious objection to fight based on religious, philosophical or moral grounds, and a belief that international disputes should be settled by peaceful means. Larousse defines it more broadly as the doctrine whose aim is the maintenance of peace between peoples. Thus in France at a time when rejection of military service was rare, it had aspects that for some included, for example, the establishment through international law of an international order outlawing war. Efforts to achieve this goal were longstanding. In 1867 the economist Frédéric Passy, usually regarded as the inspirer of subsequent French peace societies, had founded the Ligue Internationale et Permanente de la Paix. In 1892 it became the Société Française pour l'Arbitrage entre les Nations. The title connoted a more legalistic approach to peace. One of its main planks was disarmament; another was to set up an international tribunal to arbitrate in disputes between countries.¹⁰ By the 1890s the number of peace societies in Europe and North America, particularly in France, was considerable.¹¹ All such movements tended to be decried by nationalists such as Massis, who saw a link between anti-patriotism and pacifism (or pacificism, to use an almost obsolete term that does not rule out all violence, particularly a defensive war). The peace movement had links with political Radicalism.

In 'The Miracle-workers of Pacifism' Massis gives a highly selective account of the meeting of the French philosophers. According to him, the discussion centred on the kind of *patrie* that was desirable. How far could the term be extended to include the whole of Europe or even larger entities? Théodore Ruysens, a law professor, based his own broad view on his lifelong pacificism. A Catholic turned liberal Protestant, his ethical and philosophical convictions had led him to adopt a legal approach to the problem of war. He was a leading light in the Association de la Paix par le Droit - and later its president for half a century. The association's aims were

also the establishment of an international arbitration court to settle disputes. Moreover, they wished to ban standing armies, and some supported, instead of conventional military service, the setting up of local *milices* who would be mobilised only in case of war. The Swiss model served as an exemplar. This was the concept of 'the nation in arms', an idea also much canvassed by the Left, particularly Jaurès. Extremist socialists also commended it because it placed weapons permanently in the hands of the proletariat, perhaps as a prelude to 'le grand soir', the revolution that might follow an outbreak of war. Ruysen was, however, no socialist; he was closest to the liberals and Radicals.

All such views were anathema to Massis, who regarded Ruysen as suspect. Had he not spent a year in Germany, where he had contacted German pacifists such as Quidde? With like-minded French colleagues he had founded a Comité d'Entente Franco-allemand. He had even declared that he would prefer Alsace-Lorraine to remain German rather than fight a war over it. In January 1913, a few months before Massis's article, he had accepted an invitation by the Alsace branch of *Conciliation Internationale* to lecture on Franco-German understanding. On his return, the Camelots du Roi, the student members of Action Française, had disrupted his law course in Bordeaux and dubbed him 'le prussien Ruysen'.¹²

In intellectual circles Franco-German reconciliation was a live issue at the time. In January 1912 a committee entitled 'Pour mieux se connaître' was set up to promote *rapprochement*. Its French patrons (on the Comité d'honneur) included Durkheim, as well as such pacifists as Charles Gide and Victor Margueritte.

Durkheim does not appear unsympathetic to Ruysen's contention that in the future patriotism might have a broader connotation to signify loyalty to Europe, or even to the '*patrie*' of humanity. Durkheim seems to concur: 'History [can]not come to a stop.' This view is another that cannot have pleased Massis.

According to Massis's flamboyant and imaginative description, to be seen in several places, a 'timid' voice then intervened. But Paul-Henri-Benjamin Balluat, Baron de Constant de Rébecque d'Estournelles (1852-1924) was anything but shy. A consummate diplomat turned parliamentarian, he had represented France at the official Hague Peace Conferences in 1898 and 1907. In 1905 he had instituted the movement for International Conciliation, and was the author of *La conciliation internationale* (1906) and *Le rapprochement franco-allemand*. Although at the meeting he declared in

favour of the concept of 'patrie' being limited to separate countries, Massis could not accept his promotion of Franco-German understanding.

Durkheim links the extension of patriotism to the progress of pacifism - in short, the growth of internationalism, or cosmopolitanism, to use a word also much in vogue at the time. But, as Buisson, another parliamentarian, a former Director of Primary Education and also Durkheim's predecessor in the Paris chair, reminded the meeting, how could young anti-militarists - not, it must be noted, pacifists - be won over to any kind of patriotism?¹³ (At the time, workers were rebels against the army as the instrument of capitalist oppression: they particularly resented the harshness of military service and the use of troops to put down strikes.) Their sole loyalty was to the class struggle and solidarity with workers everywhere. They believed that the social revolution they sought would not be accomplished by any kind of bourgeois patriotism, however internationalist it might become.

Ruyssen implies this is a counsel of despair that must be rejected. He instances the success in 1907 of the [unofficial] Universal Peace Congress in Munich. However, he warned that if the Germans thought the French had now abandoned a peaceful stance the consequences could be dire.

A brief, also despairing, intervention by Célestin Bouglé (1870-1940), a member of the Groupe d'études socialistes, a kind of Fabian society frequented by Durkheim's younger disciples, was firmly squashed by him.

Another intervener in the debate, Frédéric Rauh, believed that France should lead the way in promoting the new kind of international patriotism whilst still retaining its own cultural identity. He may have had in mind the example of the Revolutionaries of 1792 who at Valmy not only were defending their *patrie* but believed they were advancing the cause of France and liberty everywhere. Massis probably had good reason to resent Rauh's intervention. In the early 1900s Rauh had also conducted a survey of students on patriotism, with somewhat different results from those of Massis's survey. In 1904 he had concluded that the traditional reasons given for patriotism were 'high-sounding generalities' and 'superstitions'. In 1912 he had published *Etudes de la morale*, in which he asserted the primacy of conscience over duty to one's *patrie*. As regards conscription, which bore down heavily on the working class, conscience must be the ultimate judge as to whether to accept or reject it. (This might be seen as a kind of pacifism.) Patriotism, he argued, should be used to serve the cause of internationalism.

At the meeting his stance was not so extreme. Nevertheless Durkheim condemns it. Rauh's contention that France, whilst promoting an international 'patriotism', should put forward its own culture (presumably political as well

as artistic and linguistic) as pre-eminent, for Durkheim, was 'nationalistic' and unacceptable.

Massis's article demonstrates how much patriotism and pacifism were 'sujets d'actualité' at the time and the interest that Durkheim took in them. Other intellectuals elsewhere had already joined in the debate. Brunetière, an influential literary critic, and an associate of Barrès, had published *L'idée de patrie* in 1896. For him *caritas patri et soli* is expressed in a *patrie*'s natural, historical and mystical facets. Lavis, director of the ENS, advocated patriotism and military training in schools: 'If a pupil does not become a citizen in whom has been inculcated his duties, and a soldier who loves his rifle, the primary teacher will have wasted his time.' It was a view by no means shared by all teachers. Péguy had published 'Notre patrie' in the *Cahiers de la Quinzaine*, as a ripost to Hervé's scornful 'Leur patrie' (1905). Another literary critic, Rémy de Gourmont, in *Le Joujou patriotisme*,¹⁴ roundly asserted that 'we are not patriots' and that most men were unwilling to die for their *patrie*. Such views on patriotism by intellectuals had a long history. Lamartine in *La Marseillaise de la paix* had condemned frontiers as an abhorrence but had, like Rauh, proclaimed 'ma patrie est partout où rayonne la France.' Political thinking, as we have seen, was divided. For the trade unions, Yvetot openly urged young conscripts to desert or to seize their rifles ready to turn them on their capitalist bosses. Extreme socialists such as Hervé would have no truck with conventional patriotism: how could a *patrie* be a mother, he asked, when some can sit down at the table and gorge, whilst others are neglected? The cult of *patrie* allowed the rich to profit. On the other hand moderate socialists such as Jaurès voiced a view that Durkheim almost certainly shared: if France were threatened, 'We should be the first to rush to the frontier to defend it.'¹⁵ Durkheim's comportment in the First World War, as that of most of his associates, as well, in the event, as that of most trade unionists and socialists was a striking illustration, in the final analysis, of how in 1914 Frenchmen of every belief united round the government of Poincaré in a 'Union sacrée'.

The second article, 'The intellectuals against the army', was also written just before the 'three-year law' extending conscription from two years to three and was passed, despite opposition from the Left and from many intellectuals, including Durkheim. The very title is pejorative: 'intellectuals' as a substantive was another fairly recent French coinage. For Massis intellectuals who shrank from action were useless. In the controversy over the 'three-year law' they had even lobbied against the retention in the army of the luckless

conscripts already serving, who, having completed their two-year stint, found themselves forced to serve for a further year.

For the Right, the army, *la grande muette*, was sacred. Its authority should be absolute. Thus, despite the defeat of 1870, the army continued to enjoy great prestige for a few years. The Dreyfus affair had been a catalyst for a change in public opinion. The anti-Dreyfusards, although Dreyfus had ultimately been cleared of espionage and the highest ranks in the army had been shown as accomplices in forging evidence against this Alsatian officer, persisted in asserting that the army as the mainstay of the nation should not be questioned. 'Raison d'état' should prevail even over the truth. Durkheim profoundly disagreed.

Durkheim's view was that glorification of the army should cease and that in a democracy the military should be firmly under the control of the civil power. This might be partly accomplished through an overhaul of the education system. Massis disputes this. He criticises Lanson, the 'scientific' literary historian, who sought a re-orientation of history teaching in schools. History should not recount the battles in which France has been victorious and venerate leaders who have indulged in wars of conquest. By contrast for Massis the great French leaders of the past should be lauded 'without false shame'. It is significant that those he cites as exemplars predate, with the exception of Kléber, the Alsatian general, the French Revolution.¹⁶

The two articles analysed show Durkheim as a moderate patriot and only a 'pacifist' in so far as he believed in an international order to outlaw war. He believed France should defend itself when attacked. He cannot by any stroke of the imagination be lumped with extremist socialists and trade unionists, those who rejected at the time all patriotism and considered France not worth fighting for. His 'internationalism', if it can be so termed, does not rule out, at the very least, some kind of European federalism, but one in which France would not seek to impose any kind of hegemony. Again the contrast is with the extreme Left, who interpreted internationalism as a function of the class struggle with the goal as the overthrow of capitalism. A staunch Republican, he believes the military should be subordinate to the civil authority. This much emerges from Massis's aggressive commentary, the principal merit of which is to allow us some insight into Durkheim's political philosophy, particularly on patriotism and pacifism.

NOTES

1. The writer wishes to acknowledge with thanks the assistance he has received from Bill Pickering in the compilation of this paper.
2. At age 25 Massis, together with Tarde, republished these as *L'Esprit de la nouvelle Sorbonne* (1911). In it he claimed that the teaching methods of the Sorbonne ruled out the imaginative and creative in order to concentrate on the 'scientific method' for the appraisal of knowledge. Its protagonists, the professors, it was asserted, were Dreyfusards; they were also anti-clerical. For them, mere intelligence was everything; they rejected the intuitionism of Bergson. Incidentally, even the buildings of the Sorbonne were new, save for the seventeenth century chapel.
3. The results of the survey were first published in *L'Opinion* and republished in 1913 as *Les jeunes gens d'aujourd'hui*.
4. The phrase is quoted in M. Gallo, *Le Grand Jaurès*, 1984, p. 517. (Unless otherwise stated the place of publication of all books mentioned is Paris.)
5. The report of the meeting is given in the *Bulletin de la Société française de philosophie*, séance du 30 Décembre 1907, pp. 40-69. Some of what Durkheim said has been translated into English by Neville Layne in *Sociological Inquiry*, 43 (2), pp. 101-3 (t.1973c). The extracts used have serious omissions. Layne wrote a useful introduction, 'Durkheim as Pacifist' (ibid.:99-101). See also S. Lukes, *Emile Durkheim: His Life and Work*, London, 1973, p. 363 ff. and in his bibliography, 1908a. On the question of nationalism and Durkheim, see C. J. Llobera, 'Durkheim and the National Question' in W. S. F. Pickering and H. Martines (eds), *Debating Durkheim*, London and New York: Routledge, 1993.
6. Congress of the Socialist Party at Limoges, 1906.
7. M. Toda, *Henri Massis. Un témoin de la droite intellectuelle*, Paris, 1987, p. 44, citing the first article published by Massis, 'La Sorbonne contre la culture classique.'
8. V. Grossi, *Le pacifisme européen, 1889-1914*, Brussels, 1994, p. 31.
9. S. Cooper, *Patriotic pacifism. Waging War on War in Europe, 1815-1914*, New York and Oxford, 1991, p. 60.
10. Mgr Jouin, *L'Après-Guerre 1870-1914* (Extrait de la Revue Internationale des Sociétés secrètes, Paris, 1927), p. 27. The title of the journal is revealing. The article attacks freemasons. The author stigmatises Franco-German reconciliation as a 'pacifisme de trahison et baiser des Judas'.
11. In 1913 France had 28 peace associations, with some 20,000 members. A number of other organisations such as the Fédération des Universités populaires, in which Celestin Bouglé, Durkheim's disciple, was active, were associated with the movement; if these are included the total number of sympathizers with the peace

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associations, which in 1896 had been grouped in a Bureau français de la paix, numbered over 300,000.

12. A. Encrevé (ed.) *Les Protestants: dictionnaire du monde religieux dans la France contemporaine*, 1993, heading: Ruysen.

13. Ferdinand Buisson could also not have been *persona grata* to Massis. This extremely liberal Protestant had declared, 'Every uniform is a livery, and every livery is ignominious, that of the priest as well as that of the soldier.' He had once presided over a prize competition for school textbooks, and had been instrumental in awarding the prize to an author who had termed patriotic authors 'poisoners'.

14. Article published in *Mercure de France*, 1891.

15. J. Jaurès, 'La France et le socialisme', *Dépêche de Toulouse*, January 1893.

16. Interestingly the same phenomenon occurred under the Vichy regime. The 'Révolution Nationale', as instituted by Pétain, with Massis as his youth adviser, also extolled the virtues of pre-Revolutionary France, and the heroes of those times. Indeed all the themes treated here were also topical from 1940-1942, and possibly throughout the history of the Third Republic.